

The Gulistan of Shaikh Sa'di: Biographical and Bibliographical Insights

Executive Summary

The following document provides a synthesis of key insights derived from the 1863 edition of *The Gulistan (Rose-Garden)* by Shaikh Sa'di of Shiraz, edited by Francis Johnson. Shaikh Sa'di is regarded as the "Prince of Persian moralists," a figure whose works—specifically the *Gulistan*, *Bostan*, and *Pand-Nama*—have served as foundational texts for students of the Persian language in both Asia and Europe for centuries. The source context details Sa'di's complex life, characterized by extensive travel, military captivity at the hands of the Crusaders, and ultimate religious contemplation. This specific edition of the *Gulistan* highlights a significant editorial effort to bridge the gap for European students, particularly regarding the literal translation of Arabic passages and the analysis of Persian meters, marking an advancement in the scholarly accessibility of the text.

Biographical Profile of Shaikh Sa'di

Shaikh Sa'di of Shiraz is presented as the preeminent moralist of Persia, celebrated for the harmony, richness, and simplicity of his style. His life is traditionally divided into three distinct phases: acquisition of knowledge, travel, and religious solitude.

Chronology and Early Life

- **Birth:** Born in Shiraz, Persia. There are historical discrepancies regarding his birth year; authorities cite either A.H. 571 (A.D. 1175–6) or A.H. 580 (A.D. 1184).
- **Education:** Sa'di reportedly spent the first thirty years of his life dedicated to the acquisition of knowledge.
- **Longevity:** He lived to a very advanced age. Evidence suggests he reached 120 lunar years (approximately 116 solar years).

Travels and Captivity

In his middle age, Sa'di traveled extensively across Asia, from the Nile to the Ganges. He is said to have performed the pilgrimage to Mecca fourteen times.

- **Encounter with Crusaders:** While performing a pilgrimage to Jerusalem, Sa'di was taken prisoner by the Crusaders ("the Franks") and forced into manual labor in the trenches of Tripoli.
- **Ransom and Marriage:** He was ransomed for ten dinars by a wealthy merchant from Aleppo. The merchant subsequently married his daughter to Sa'di with a dowry of one hundred gold pieces. This marriage was notably difficult; Sa'di remarked on his wife's sharp tongue, noting that while her father ransomed him for ten dinars, he effectively "sold" Sa'di into her hands for a hundred.

Later Years and Death

- **Contemplation:** Sa'di devoted the final thirty years of his life to solitude and religious contemplation.

- **Patronage:** During his life, he enjoyed the support of the Atabek princes, the ruling dynasty in Shiraz.
- **Death:** He died in A.H. 691 (A.D. 1292). His decease is memorialized by the word *Noble* (نبيل), which, according to the abjad system, calculates to the year 691.

Literary Impact and Themes

Sa'di's genius is defined by his ability to unfold moral truths through pleasing narratives embellished with poetic grace. His primary objective was to direct his countrymen toward "probity and honour."

- **Core Works:**
 - *The Gulistan* (The Rose-Garden)
 - *The Bostan*
 - *The Pand-Nama*
- **Educational Significance:** These works are the standard text-books for beginners of the Persian language globally.
- **Style:** His writing is noted for its "unction," "chasteness," and the powerful charm of its rhythm and alliteration, which are specifically designed to appeal to the "Oriental ear."

Translation and Editorial History of the *Gulistan*

The *Gulistan* has been accessible to the European public for over two centuries through various translations and editions.

Notable Historical Editions

Translator/Editor, Language/Region, Notes

Olearius, German, Translated over 200 years prior to 1863.

Gentius, Latin (Amsterdam, 1651), "A ""splendid"" folio edition with valuable notes."

Gladwin, English, A reprint and translation of Gentius's work (~1803).

James Dumoulin, Calcutta (1806), Regarded as a superior edition of both text and translation.

J. Ross, English, "Described as an ""amusing"" but not entirely accurate translation."

Professor E. B. Eastwick, English, "Considered the most ""masterly"" translation; the first to render the poetic portions into English verse."

M. Ch. Defremery, French, An accurate translation enriched with historical and geographical annotations.

The 1863 Francis Johnson Edition

The 1863 edition published by Stephen Austin was designed to address specific deficiencies in previous versions, particularly the lack of assistance for students regarding Arabic content and Persian metrics.

Key Contributions and Collaborations

- **Dr. Sprenger:** The editor adopted the readings from Dr. Sprenger's 1851 Calcutta edition, considered the most "genuine and authentic version" of the text.

- **Dr. Duncan Forbes:** Contributed significantly to the final stages of the work by providing a literal translation of all Arabic portions. He also provided an analysis of Persian metres for the first book.
- **M. Ch. Defremery:** His historical and geographical annotations were utilized in the compilation of the vocabulary.

Treatment of Arabic Passages

The *Gulistan* contains numerous sentences and verses written purely in Arabic. The 1863 edition categorizes these into four heads in its Appendix:

1. Quotations from the **Kur'an** .
2. **Traditions** concerning Muhammad.
3. **Sayings** of the chief Shaikhs or doctors of Islam.
4. **Proverbs** and scraps of poetry. This edition emphasizes that these Arabic portions are too important to be ignored, as they constitute an integral part of the work's moral and literary structure.